

Research Study Idea:

The Effect of Documentary Film on Library Stakeholders' Impression of Librarianship

Amanda M. Clark

Morgridge College of Education, University of Denver

RMS 4900: Educational Research and Measurement

Dr. Spencer Acadia

September 27, 2025

Topic

There has recently been a proliferation of news stories about librarians being harassed, investigated, fired, forced to quit, threatened online, personally attacked, sued, and campaigned against. The political, moral, religious, and legislative justifications for this mistreatment do not align with the values of library professionals who are trained to develop collections that appeal to a wide range of interests, advocate for access, and oppose censorship. To be precise, librarians are taught to adhere to the rights afforded to all people within the United States in the First Amendment, protecting the idea of intellectual freedom, thereby maintaining a functioning democracy.

A plethora of literature on the effects of book bans on library work exists. Topics include increased circulation in states without bans; collection development impact; defending access for marginalized groups and the intellectual freedom and growth of children; self-censorship; and many others (Ananthakrishnan et al., 2025; Becnel & Moeller, 2020; Cockcroft, 2023; Dawkins, 2018; Teel, 2023). These issues deserve ongoing attention as they are factors of job satisfaction, but I had difficulty locating quantitative, peer-reviewed data on the nexus between job satisfaction of public and school librarians and book bans in the past 5 years. Therefore, a pilot study exploring the feasibility of a program designed to help librarians stimulate conversation with library stakeholders about the professional hurdles created by book bans came to mind. The goal of this research is not to “solve” the issue of censorship but instead to examine any changes in how library stakeholders view librarianship before and after discussing the experiences of librarians who are managing book bans.

Questions

I am working on the issue of public perception because I want to find out whether library stakeholders who engage in conversation about the obstacles book bans create for professional

librarians experience perspective changes in order to create a program that has the potential to improve job conditions for librarians. The mechanism that will allow participants to start this conversation in their respective communities is an invitation to stakeholders to attend a screening of *The Librarians*, a 2025 documentary film about the recent, alarming experiences of librarians across the country. Before the screening, a survey will measure initial impressions. The program will include a toolkit that walks librarians and stakeholders through a series of discussion questions asked after the screening to open a discourse on the effects book bans have on professional librarians. Discussions will be observed and a subsequent survey will be conducted to evaluate whether stakeholders experienced any shift in their perception of librarianship and to what degree.

Problem

Many anti-censorship resources, training programs, and financial support funds exist to help librarians who are caught in the crosshairs of book banning but, in my initial research, I was unable to locate a formal program that sought to bridge the gap between pro and anti-censorship viewpoints with respect to the mistreatment librarians face as a result of censorship. Therefore, the specific problem this pilot study seeks to address is whether a non-partisan, sincere program that opens a discourse on the issue of the professional impacts of book bans can be created that librarians feel safe using in their own communities.

The fears and anxieties that this topic elicits in librarians are not baseless. Sharp et al. (2024) found that “many librarians cite feeling physically unsafe and verbally harassed in their workplaces as their reason for wanting to leave librarianship,” and that librarians worry about being “called to the carpet, fired, or harmed by an irate patron” (para. 2). Anecdotal evidence is not the only indication that librarians are facing troubling times. According to the American Library Association, 133 bills that seek to criminalize librarians and/or govern, control, ban, and censor library materials have been proposed so far

in 2025. However, only 41 bills that seek to protect professional librarians, support free expression, and uphold the right to read have been proposed (American Library Association, 2025). These numbers highlight the need for momentum on this topic.

To address this imbalance and the chilling effect censorship has on librarians, conversations with stakeholders are essential. Starting these conversations is difficult but a film screening feels like a respectable entry point. The concept of using a documentary film as the jumping off point for constructive dialogue came when I saw an ad for *The Librarians* but was reinforced by successful research on the effect of documentary film on increased awareness of social issues. Awareness around polarized issues like sexism in STEM, food production and consumption, the prison industrial complex, health care coverage, and global warming have all been impacted by the ability of documentary film to humanize complex subjects (Pietri et al., 2024; Flowers & Swan, 2011; Whiteman, 2009; Nisbet & Aufderheide, 2009).

Answering the Research Question

Observing conversation around the themes of the documentary film and surveying participants might serve to illuminate the practicability of continuing a similar program in other communities. Accordingly, the research question that drives this study is: what effect, if any, does watching the 2025 documentary film *The Librarians* have on library stakeholders' impression of librarianship in the context of book bans in Williamson County, Texas? For the purposes of this research, library stakeholders include public and school librarians, public and school library administrators, school board officials, and parents of children attending public school in Williamson County, Texas.

To answer this research question, a mixed methods approach will be utilized. A survey that gathers quantitative and qualitative data about pre- and post-exposure attitudes and attitude shifts,

cognitive and emotional engagement, perceived changes in views, and knowledge and misconception checks will be used. Additionally, discussions about the themes within the film will be analyzed to provide qualitative data about the program itself. Given the experimental nature of this study, a control group that does not watch the film may need to be used. To minimize bias in this research, I will operationalize key terms like “attitude shift,” use Likert scales to design valid measures, test questions for clarity and consistency, consider the use of a reflexive journal, and include diverse perspectives in the results.

References

American Library Association. (2025, September 24). *Adverse legislation in the states*.

<https://www.ala.org/advocacy/adverse-legislation-states> (Accessed September 24, 2025).

Document ID: 32cbb521-5c74-4dd2-b3ad-f560be1d47c5

Ananthakrishnan, U. M., Basavaraj, N., Karmegam, S. R., Sen, A., & Smith, M. D. (2025). Book bans in

American libraries: Impact of politics on inclusive content consumption. *Marketing Science*,

44(4), 933–953. <https://doi.org/10.1287/mksc.2024.0716>

Becnel, K., & Moeller, R. A. (2020). I'm conflicted about my shelf of censorship: High school library

graphic novel collection development in North Carolina, USA. *School Libraries Worldwide*, 26(1),

124–135. <https://doi.org/10.29173/slw8252>

Cockcroft, M. (2023). A big chill: 729 school librarians reveal how censorship impacts their life and work.

School Library Journal, 69(9), 30-34.

https://du.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UODE_INST/1uqj623/cdi_proquest_reports_28

[58963916](https://du.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UODE_INST/1uqj623/cdi_proquest_reports_28)

Dawkins, A. M. (2018). The decision by school librarians to self-censor: The impact of perceived

administrative discomfort. *Teacher Librarian*, 45(3), 8–12.

[https://du.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/magazines/decision-school-](https://du.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/magazines/decision-school-librarians-self-censor/docview/2015780220/se-2)

[librarians-self-censor/docview/2015780220/se-2](https://du.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/magazines/decision-school-librarians-self-censor/docview/2015780220/se-2)

Flowers, R., & Swan, E. (2011). 'Eating at us': Representations of knowledge in the activist documentary

film Food, Inc. *Studies in the Education of Adults*, 43(2), 234–250.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/02660830.2011.11661615>

Nisbet, M. C., & Aufderheide, P. (2009). Documentary film: Towards a research agenda on forms, functions, and impacts. *Mass Communication and Society*, 12(4), 450–456.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/15205430903276863>

Pietri, E. S., Weigold, A., Munoz, L. M. P., & Moss-Racusin, C. A. (2024). Examining how a documentary film can serve as an intervention to shift attitudes and behaviours around sexism in STEM.

Scientific Reports, 14(1), 1–13. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-024-72395-y>

Sharp, A., McClure, J., Taylor, C. (2024). Fear and loathing in Tennessee. *Tennessee Libraries*, 74(1).

<https://research-ebsco-com.du.idm.oclc.org/c/q5iacu/viewer/html/7r4p4v2obn?auth-callid=d6c77494-6a39-48ac-ba06-33b18d4767b2>

Teel, Z. A. (2023). Guardians of freedom: Examining privacy, censorship, and government legislation in collection development. *Serials Librarian*, 84(1–4), 11–16.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/0361526X.2023.2245862>

Whiteman, D. (2009). Documentary film as policy analysis: The impact of yes, in my backyard on activists, agendas, and policy. *Mass Communication & Society*, 12(4), 457–477.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/15205430903237816>